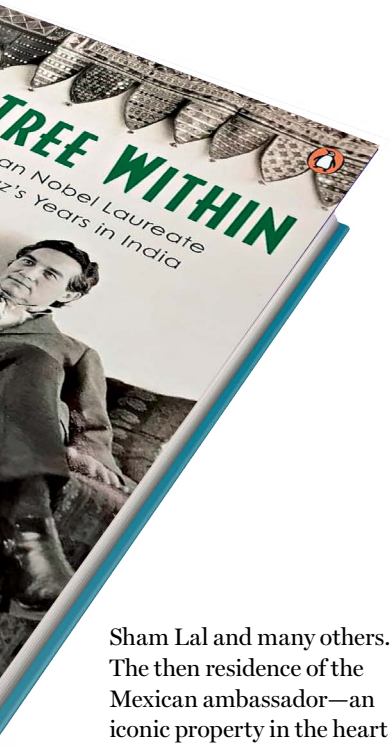


Sham Lal and many others. The then residence of the Mexican ambassador—an iconic property in the heart of Lutyens' Delhi—is very much part of this landscape of culture and literature.

Paz left India in 1968 when he resigned from the diplomatic service in protest over the shooting down of student protesters in large numbers in Mexico. India, however, remained with him, and his work reflects it in many ways.

Chakravarty is very clearly an admirer but not an uncritical one. He notes, for instance, that Paz's gaze on occasion would be somewhat "Orientalist in the Saidian sense", with its sweeping generalisation and a utopian view of the East.

This is a meaty but readable account of Octavio Paz and India, and it comes with numerous surprisingly informative asides and insights into Mexico and India. *The Tree Within* also provides an insight into what a powerful diplomatic asset a major cultural figure can be as an ambassador. ■

—T.C.A. Raghavan

BOOKS ▼

What Lies Beneath Serene Surfaces

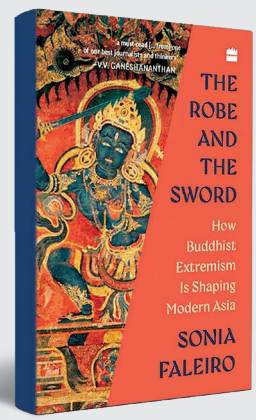
This short and crisply written book raises some serious questions about **BUDDHIST PACIFISM**

Sonia Faleiro's *The Robe and the Sword: How Buddhist Extremism is Shaping Modern Asia* explodes a set of myths about Buddhism—namely, that it is an essentially non-violent religion; its adherents believe in kindness and tolerance; and that it urges us away from earthly desire. If Faleiro's aim is to extinguish any illusions about Buddhism that have enabled its insinuation into the western "wellness aisle", then she succeeds spectacularly!

It is a short and crisply written book that takes us on a vertiginous journey through Sri Lanka, Myanmar and Thailand, with a couple of pit stops in India and Tibet. On the surface, the writing is both prosaic and elegant—although perhaps a bit too parsimonious at times. But just underneath the surface, there is a boiling rage against the ultranationalist extremism espoused by some Buddhist monks in places like Sri Lanka and Myanmar, aiding and abetting violence (and, at least in one case, genocide) against non-Buddhists—most egregiously, against Muslim minorities. We also learn about patriarchy in Buddhism, particularly in the Theravada tradition, and the crass materialism of some Buddhist monks that scaffolds the temple-tourism complex in Thailand.

The book is somewhat less successful, however, in offering a synoptic view of the conflicts it describes. To be sure, it provides a nuanced account of monks who have resisted an ascendant and transnational form of ethnocentrism (and even risked their lives in so doing) and those who have attempted to unravel some of the patriarchy. But Faleiro could have delved deeper into the politics of colonialism, class and mercantile emigration, toward which the book frequently gestures. The analysis also potentially underemphasises the militant tactics sometimes used by the oppressed groups. Such is the case, for example, with the Arakan Rohingya Salvation Army. ■

—Cyril Ghosh



THE ROBE AND THE SWORD HOW BUDDHIST EXTREMISM IS SHAPING MODERN ASIA
By Sonia Faleiro
HARPERCOLLINS INDIA
₹599; 160 pages

THERE IS A BOILING RAGE IN THE BOOK AGAINST **THE ULTRANATIONALIST** EXTREMISM ESPOUSED BY SOME BUDDHIST MONKS IN SRI LANKA AND MYANMAR